

At the 1953 Census, similar but more comprehensive information was collected from certain sample households. At the 1963 Census, no item on fertility was included. At the 1971 Census, however, detailed questions on fertility were asked in respect of a 10 percent sample of census blocks from ever married women below 50 years.

These were :-

- (1) Age at first marriage
- (2) Duration of first marriage
- (3) Children ever born alive
- (4) Children now living
- (5) Particulars of live-births, if any, occurring during the last five years.

Particulars were also asked in respect of second or subsequent marriages.

7.2 Statistics of birth registration

The Registrar-General of Sri Lanka has maintained statistics of birth registration by maternal age commencing from 1952. A survey conducted by the Department of Census and Statistics in 1953 revealed that completeness of birth registration was 88.1 percent¹ while a similar survey in 1967 disclosed completeness to the level of 98.7 percent.² This high degree of completeness facilitates fertility analysis to a large extent. Thus the data used in the calculation of various fertility indices such as general fertility rate, age specific fertility rate, age specific marital fertility rates and total fertility rates in 1953, 1963 and 1971 are from the Registrar-General's Department.

7.3 Trends in age at first marriage

Table 7.1 presents the singulate mean age at marriage for males and females, computed from the census data for 1946, 1953, 1963 and 1971 for males and females. The most striking feature to be noted is that the female age at marriage has risen from 20.7 years in 1946, through 20.9 in 1953 and 22.1 in 1963 to 23.5 in 1971 respectively, while that of the male had registered only a slight increase from 27.0 years in 1946 through 27.2 in 1953 and 27.9 in 1963 to 28.0 in 1971³. It may also be observed that the difference between the average age at marriage for males and females has been reduced from 6.3 years in 1946 to 4.5 years in 1971.

TABLE 7.1 : MEAN AGE AT MARRIAGE 1946, 1953, 1963 AND 1971

Census Year	Average age at marriage (in years)		Difference
	Males	Females	
1946	27.0	20.7	6.3
1953	27.2	20.9	6.3
1963	27.9	22.1	5.8
1971	28.0	23.5	4.5

1 I.W. Kannangara, Monograph I: Department of Census and Statistics 1953.

2 W.M.L.S. Aponso, Study of the Extent of under-registration of births and deaths in Ceylon, Department of Census and Statistics Sri Lanka 1970.

3 Changing Nuptiality Patterns in Sri Lanka 1901-1971, Dallas F.S. Fernando, Population Studies 29, 2 July, 1975.